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| 201

companies, listing Essar Energy, and forging a telecom joint venture with Hutchison Whampoa.

"He was a big-picture visionary with an endearing charm, a gentleman to the core with an impish sense of humour," says Sandip Das, former CEO of Hutchison-Essar Telecom. Das fondly remembers the harmonious partnership between Shashikant and Ravi Ruia, describing it as "a perfect blend of Yin and Yang in business *jugalbandi*". Their initials lent Essar its name, a hallmark of enterprise and ambition.

However, the years ahead were turbulent. Delays in an oil refinery project compounded existing challenges.

The global financial crisis depressed steel prices, exacerbating the group's mounting debt, which peaked at \$25 billion. Essar even-

tually had to sell its prized assets, leaving the group a shadow of its former self. Yet, Ruia remained composed through it all. "Even during the toughest times, he showed remarkable patience," says Balakrishnan.

Essar Steel also featured among the first companies, the so-called 'dirty dozen', identified under India's 2017 Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code—a moment emblematic of the group's struggle. That was a time when Essar dominated the headlines of the pink papers.

The company had already gone through multiple rounds of financial restructuring, with banks incurring significant losses.

However, the Ruia family challenged the company's insolvency proceedings under the IBC. The move sparked a legal battle, attracting widespread attention. Matters

escalated further when the IBC barred promoters from reclaiming control of companies they had lost, intensifying the headlines and litigation that followed. But Essar emerged unscathed and was the only one to pay back the debt fully.

Today, Essar 2.0 emerges from his legacy, with a renewed focus on energy, infrastructure, metals, technology, and retail. The emphasis now is on leveraging opportunities in India's rapidly evolving economy.

Ruia's enduring contribution is his audacious vision, his ability to inspire loyalty from workers and top executives alike, and his knack for making people feel he was "one of them". As Balakrishnan aptly puts it: "That trait is rare—and invaluable." **BT**

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